



VOLUME-1
EPISODE-1
GUARDIANS SYNDICATE

THE CITY OF
ASHTON
SHIMMERED UNDER
ITS USUAL GLOW,
ALIVE WITH LIGHT
AND MOVEMENT...



UNTIL A THUNDEROUS
EXPLOSION RIPPED THROUGH
ITS CENTER AND SHATTERED
THE ILLUSION OF PEACE.



MICRO-DRONES SWARMED
THROUGH THE AIR, BURSTING
ONE AFTER ANOTHER,
TEARING INTO BUILDINGS
AND STREETS.



PANIC SPREAD INSTANTLY.
PEOPLE RAN BLINDLY
TO ESCAPE.



SMOKE THICKENED
THE SKYLINE,
SIRENS SCREAMED
IN EVERY DIRECTION...



AND RISING ABOVE
IT ALL CAME A
DISTORTED,
UNHINGED LAUGH.



AT THE CENTER OF THE DESTRUCTION STOOD GLOW PLUG, HIS BODY RADIATING UNSTABLE ENERGY AS LIGHT BENT AND FLICKERED AROUND HIM LIKE IT WAS ALIVE.

GUARDIANS!

HIS VOICE ECHOED THROUGH THE CHAOS, INVITING A FIGHT HE CLEARLY ENJOYED.

SEVENTH TIME'S THE CHARM!

GLOW PLUG—THE MAN WHO CONTINUES TO RETURN. DEFEATED SIX TIMES BY THE GUARDIANS...

NOW HE RETURNS. 7TH TIME.

UPGRADED. STRONGER. DEADLIER THAN EVER.

HIS NEW TECH CAPTURES INNOCENT PEOPLE WITH EASE, TURNING THE CITY INTO HIS PLAYGROUND.

PEOPLE SCREAMED. BUILDINGS SHAKEN. HOPE FLICKERED.

THIS TIME I WILL NOT BACKOFF HAHAAH!



WITH A SNAP OF HIS FINGERS, LIGHT FOLDED BEHIND HIM AND FORMED INTO A MASSIVE WEAPON—THE **GLOWTANK**.



ITS FOUR ROTATING BARRELS LIT UP AND BEGAN FIRING RAPIDLY, UNLEASHING A RELENTLESS BARRAGE.

BRRRRRAATATATAT!



SHAPE SHIFTER BARELY ESCAPED, STRETCHING AND SNAPPING HIS BODY BEHIND A WRECKED CAR...

THOOM!



...AS EXPLOSIONS RIPPED THROUGH THE STREET.



AH...

SHING!



THOOOOM!



HURRKK!



THE OLD GUY.



A BLINDING FLASH ERUPTED FROM THE GLOWTANK.

THE INTENSE LIGHT REFLECTED OFF EXTINCT'S BODY, AMPLIFYING THE BRIGHTNESS...

...LEAVING HIM MOMENTARILY BLINDED.

NOT THIS TIME, OLD BOY.

THEN, UNEXPECTEDLY, THE GLOWTANK STOPPED FIRING.

WHAT—?

THE AIR CHANGED.

A SOFT, POWERFUL GLOW DESCENDED FROM ABOVE.

QUEEN, THE WHITE WITCH PEOPLE STARTED CHEERING.

READY FOR ANOTHER HUMILIATION, GLOW PLUG?

WITH A SIMPLE SWEEP OF HER HAND, THE DRONES MALFUNCTIONED AND FELL FROM THE SKY—LIFELESS.



ONCE AGAIN, GLOW PLUG'S
DRONES AND TANK RESUMED
THEIR DESTRUCTION.

NO MATTER HOW HARD SHAPE SHIFTER,
EXTINCT, AND QUEEN FOUGHT, THEY
COULDN'T STOP THE DEVASTATION.

HIGH ABOVE THE CITY, ON TOP OF A BUILDING,
A COLD MASKED FIGURE STOOD SILENTLY,
WATCHING EVERYTHING UNFOLD BELOW.

RAMPAGE.

WITHOUT HESITATION,
HE STEPPED FORWARD...

...AND JUMPED.

HIS DESCENT WAS CONTROLLED.
SILENT. DEADLY.

THE MOMENT HE LANDED—

HIS BLADES FROM HIS BACK MOVED. IN A SINGLE,
CLEAN STRIKE, THE GLOWTANK WAS SLICED APART
PERMANENTLY.

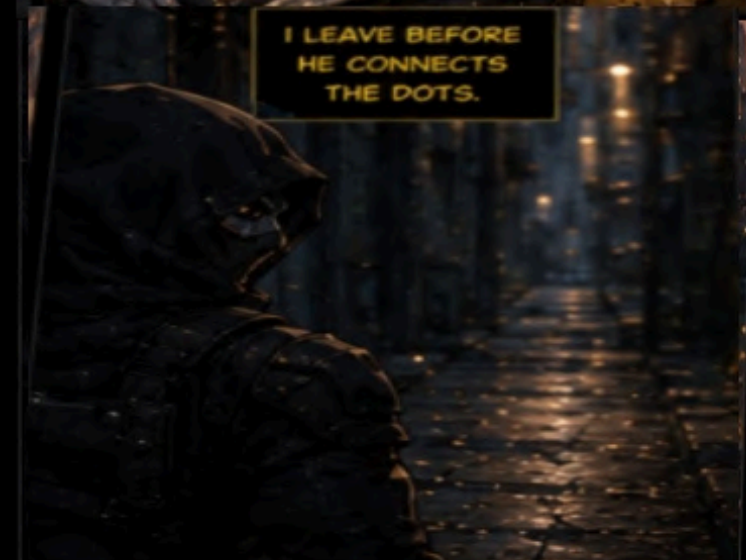
WITHOUT STOPPING, HE CUT THROUGH
MULTIPLE DRONES WITH PRECISION.
HIS MOVEMENTS—SHARP. EFFICIENT.

ONCE AGAIN, THE
GREATEST SWORDSMAN
IS HERE. I WILL GIVE
YOU MORE CHALLENGE,
MAN.









A LITTLE DAMAGE
TO THE BUILDINGS
AND ROADS...
BUT NO ONE WAS
HARMED.

EVERYONE IS SAFE.



EXTINCT
PUT A MUTANT
CUFFS PUTTING
BEHIND THE
HANDS OF GLOW
PLUG...



...AND MOVING
THE DAMAGED
GLOW PLUG.



HAZARD AND
SHAPE SHIFTER
HELPED PEOPLE
WHO WERE
LITTLE HURT AND
HELPED CLEANING
THE DAMAGE
PROPERTIES.

BUT ALPHA'S
ATTENTION
WASN'T ON HIM.

HE WAS STILL
THINKING,
TRYING TO
UNDERSTAND
WHAT HAD JUST
HAPPENED.



ALPHA,
IT'S ALREADY
TIME. WE NEED TO
GO TO THE
CEREMONY.



...
(NOD)



ASHTON BEGAN
TO SETTLE,
BUT THE SILENCE
THAT FOLLOWED
DIDN'T FEEL LIKE
PEACE.

IT FELT LIKE
SOMETHING HAD
JUST BEGUN.



THE SNIPER WHO
THREW HIS MASK AWAY,
SLIPPED AWAY THROUGH
THE CITY'S FORGOTTEN
PASSAGES AND
DISAPPEARED INTO THE
DARKER SIDE OF ASHTON.

HERE, THE BEAUTIFUL
TOWERS AND GLOWING
STREETS GAVE WAY TO
ABANDONED FACTORIES,
RUSTED BRIDGES, BROKEN
BUILDINGS, AND NARROW
ALLEYS ILLUMINATED
ONLY BY DYING
NEON SIGNS.



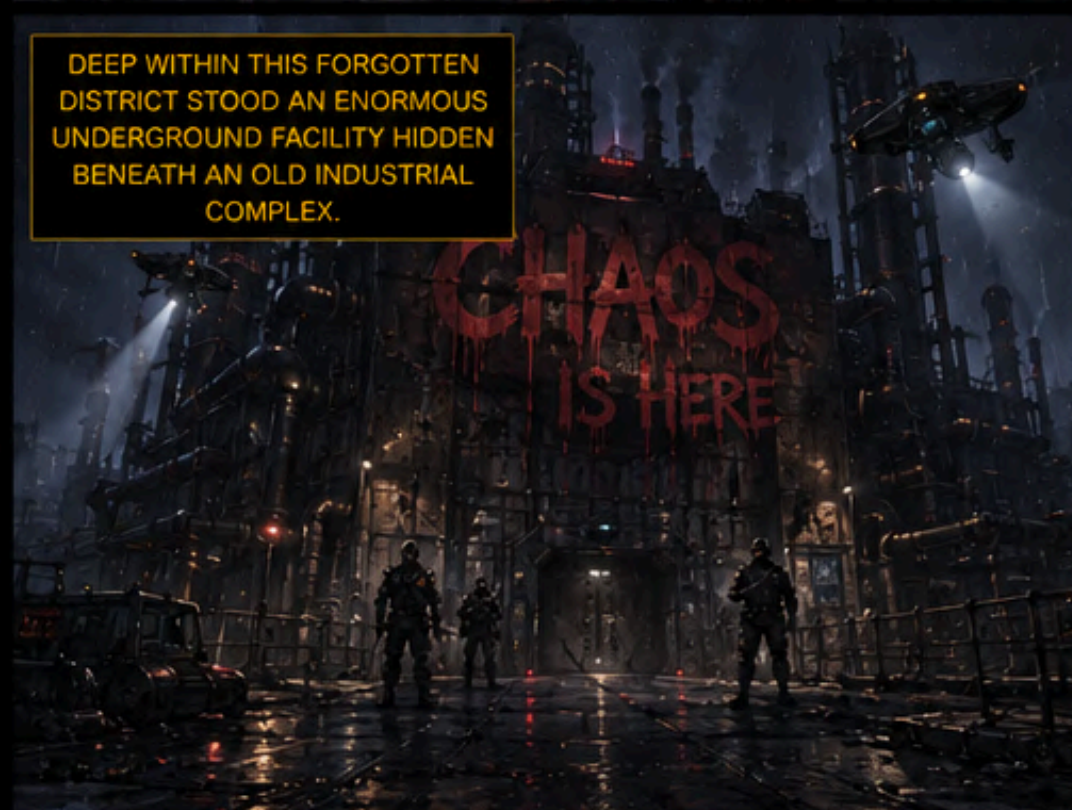
THIS WAS THE PART OF THE CITY
PEOPLE AVOIDED AFTER SUNSET—
THE PLACE WHERE ILLEGAL WEAPONS
CHANGED HANDS,



CRIMINALS DISAPPEARED,
AND THE LAW RARELY
REACHED.



DEEP WITHIN THIS FORGOTTEN
DISTRICT STOOD AN ENORMOUS
UNDERGROUND FACILITY HIDDEN
BENEATH AN OLD INDUSTRIAL
COMPLEX.



ITS ENTRANCE WAS GUARDED
BY ARMED MEN, SURVEILLANCE
MACHINES, AND STRANGE
TECHNOLOGICAL DEVICES.

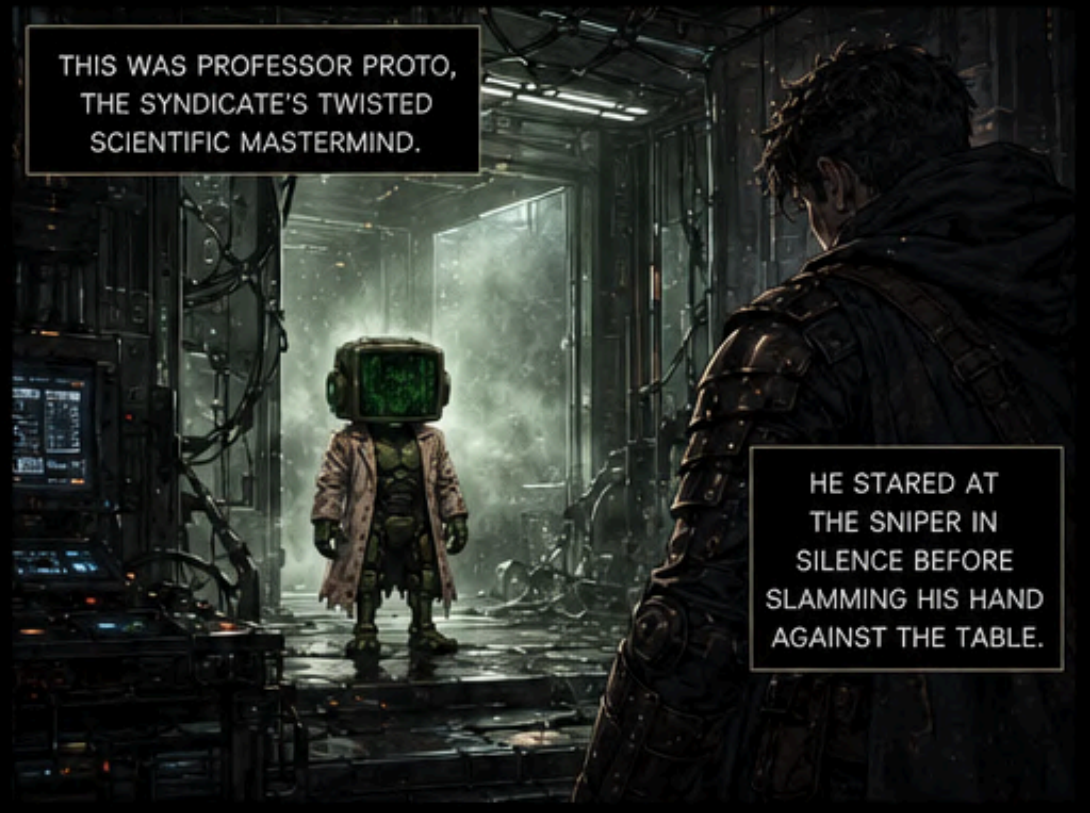
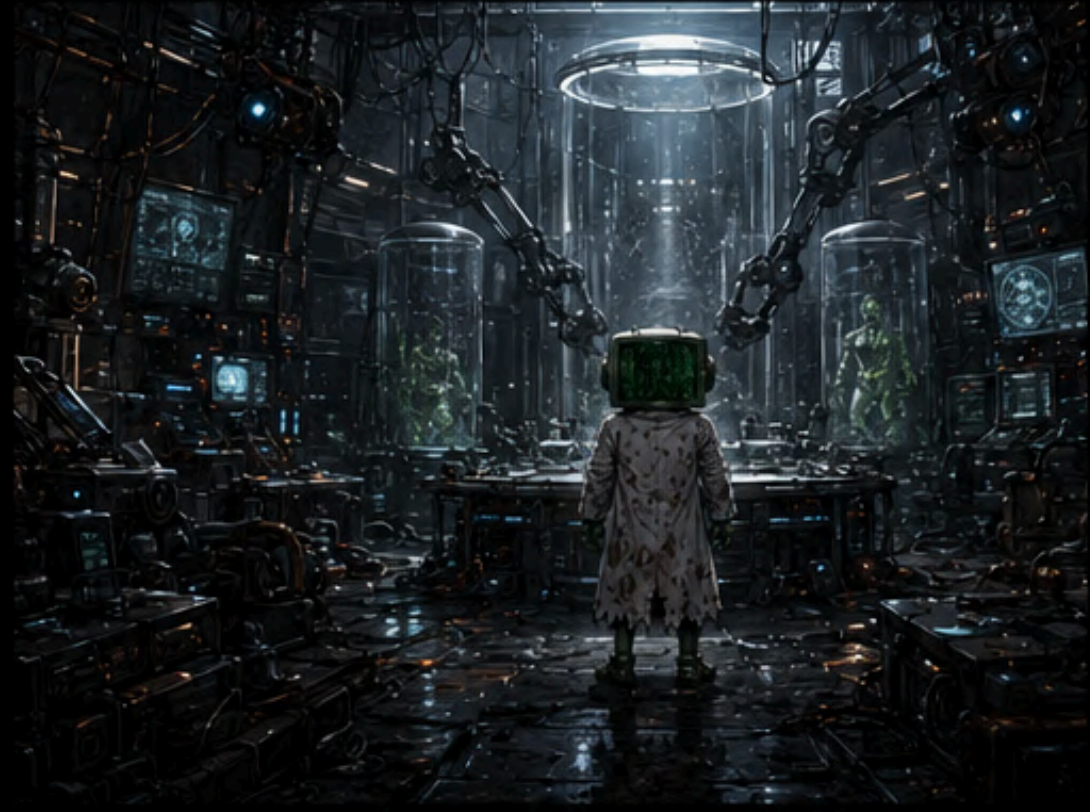


EVERYONE IN THE CITY
KNEW THE NAME WHISPERED
BEHIND CLOSED DOORS—
CHAOS SYNDICATE.

THE SNIPER ENTERED THE FACILITY AND
WALKED THROUGH ITS DARK METALLIC
CORRIDORS UNTIL HE REACHED A
MASSIVE LABORATORY.



SCREENS DISPLAYED
SURVEILLANCE FOOTAGE OF ALPHA,
THE GUARDIANS, AND THE RECENT
BATTLE THAT HAPPENED IN ASHTON.



ASHTON GATHERED
IN SILENCE BENEATH
A CLEAR SKY.

IN THE MIDDLE OF A
VAST GREEN OPEN
GROUND, A GRAND
MEMORIAL STAGE
STOOD SURROUNDED
BY HUNDREDS OF
CIVILIANS, GUARDIANS,
OFFICIALS, AND HEROES
FROM ACROSS THE CITY.



AT THE CENTER WAS
A COVERED STATUE
OF BELLY MAN,
THE FALLEN
GUARDIAN SYNDICATE.



THE PRESIDENT OF THE
GUARDIANS SYNDICATE,
ADAM TAYLOR, STEPPED
ONTO THE STAGE AND
SPOKE FIRST.

BELLY MAN WAS
CAPTURED DURING A
MISSION THAT FAILED FAR
BEYOND OUR BORDERS.
HE WAS TAKEN PRISONER
AND SUBJECTED TO
BRUTAL TORTURE. THEY
DEMANDED INFORMATION
ABOUT OUR GUARDIANS,
OUR OPERATIONS, AND
OUR COUNTRY.

BUT BELLY MAN REFUSED
TO GIVE THEM A SINGLE
PIECE OF INFORMATION.
THEY BROKE HIS BODY,
BUT THEY COULD NOT
BREAK HIS LOYALTY.

HE PROTECTED HIS COUNTRY
UNTIL HIS FINAL BREATH. THAT
IS THE KIND OF COURAGE THAT
CANNOT BE MEASURED BY
STRENGTH ALONE.



TO BELLY MAN'S
FAMILY—THANK YOU.
THERE ARE NO WORDS
ENOUGH FOR THE
SACRIFICE YOU HAVE
ENDURED.

YOUR PAIN IS OUR
PAIN, AND YOUR
STRENGTH INSPIRES
THIS WHOLE CITY.

BELLY MAN GAVE
YEARS OF HIS LIFE
TO THIS SYNDICATE,
TO THIS CITY, AND
TO THIS COUNTRY.

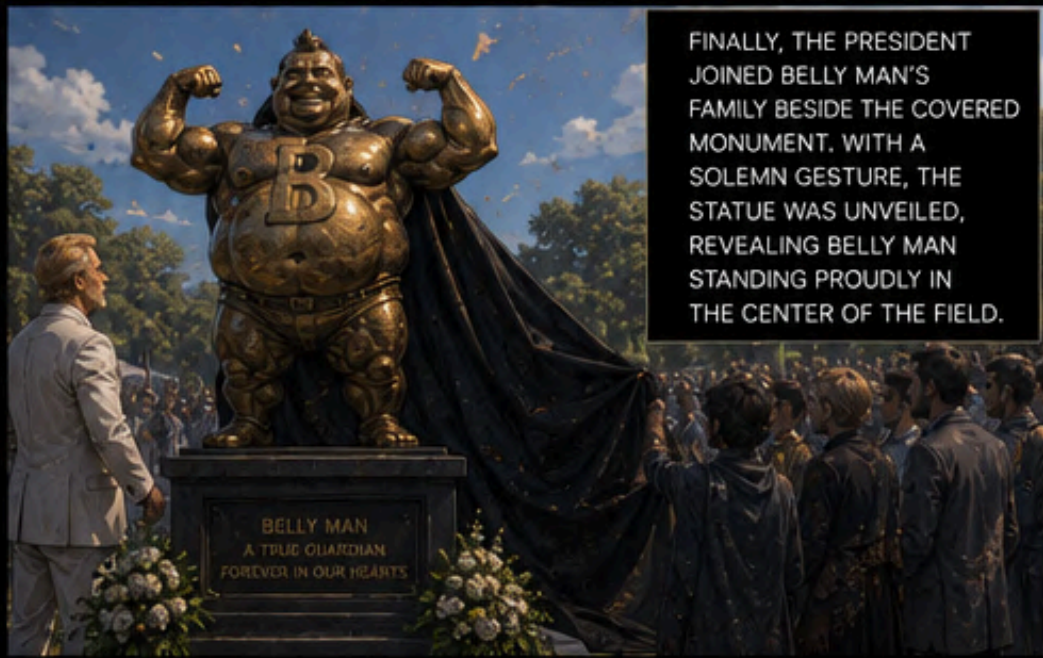
WE HONOR HIM
TODAY, AND WE
WILL NEVER
FORGET HIM.



ONE AFTER ANOTHER, THE HEROES
STEPPED FORWARD AND DELIVERED
THEIR TRIBUTES, THOUGH THE CROWD
COULD HEAR ONLY FRAGMENTS AS
THOUSANDS STOOD IN RESPECTFUL
SILENCE.



FINALLY, THE PRESIDENT
JOINED BELLY MAN'S
FAMILY BESIDE THE COVERED
MONUMENT. WITH A
SOLEMN GESTURE, THE
STATUE WAS UNVEILED,
REVEALING BELLY MAN
STANDING PROUDLY IN
THE CENTER OF THE FIELD.



THE CROWD ERUPTED
INTO APPLAUSE.



BUT THE MOMENT QUICKLY
SETTLED INTO SILENCE AS
QUEEN APPROACHED THE
MICROPHONE.

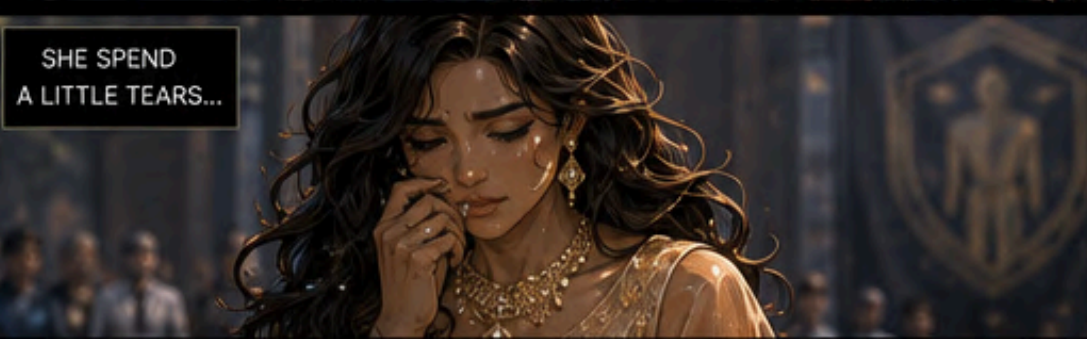
BELLY MAN DIDN'T
JUST FIGHT BECAUSE
HE WAS STRONG.

HE FOUGHT BECAUSE
PEOPLE NEEDED SOMEONE
TO STAND BETWEEN THEM
AND DANGER.

TODAY, WE DON'T MOURN
ONLY A HERO—WE
REMEMBER A MAN WHO
CHOSE TO PROTECT OTHERS
EVEN WHEN HE KNEW THE
COST.

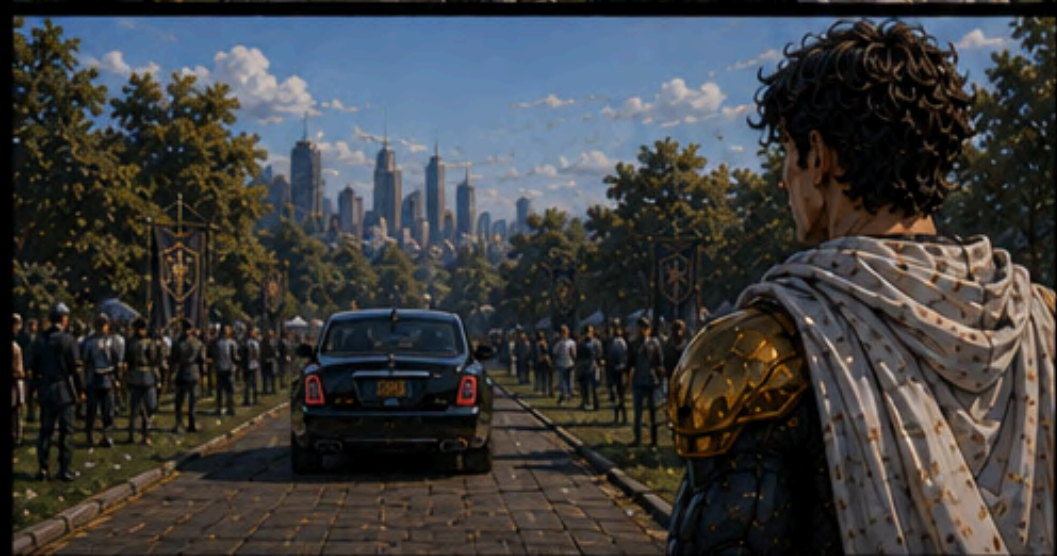


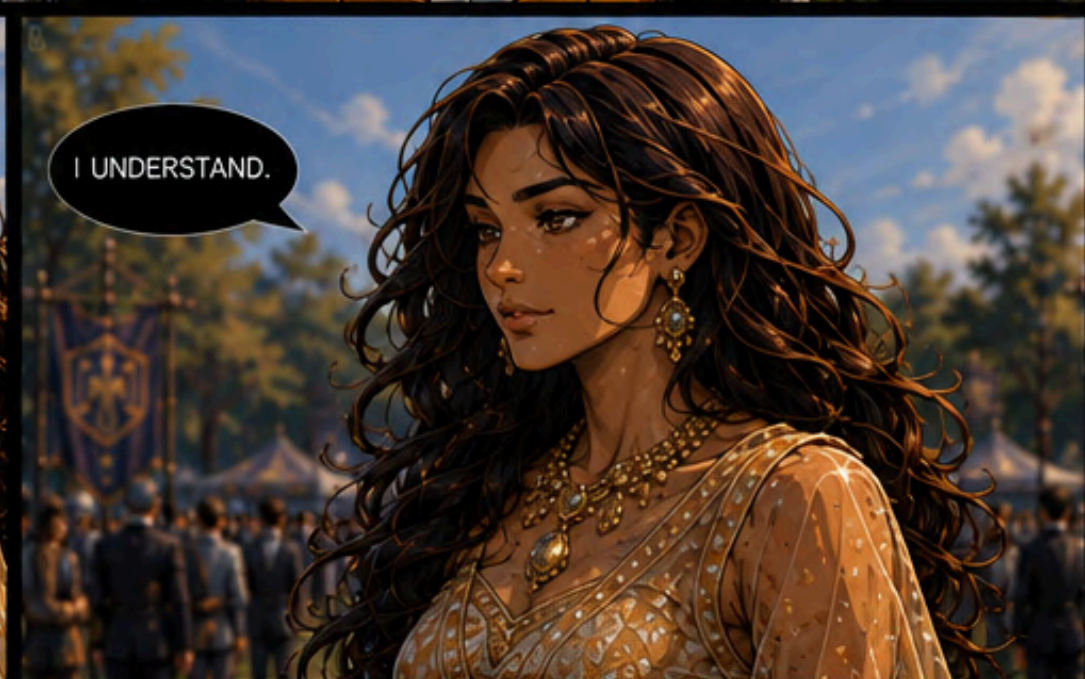
SHE SPEND
A LITTLE TEARS...



...AND THEN
STEPPED ASIDE.







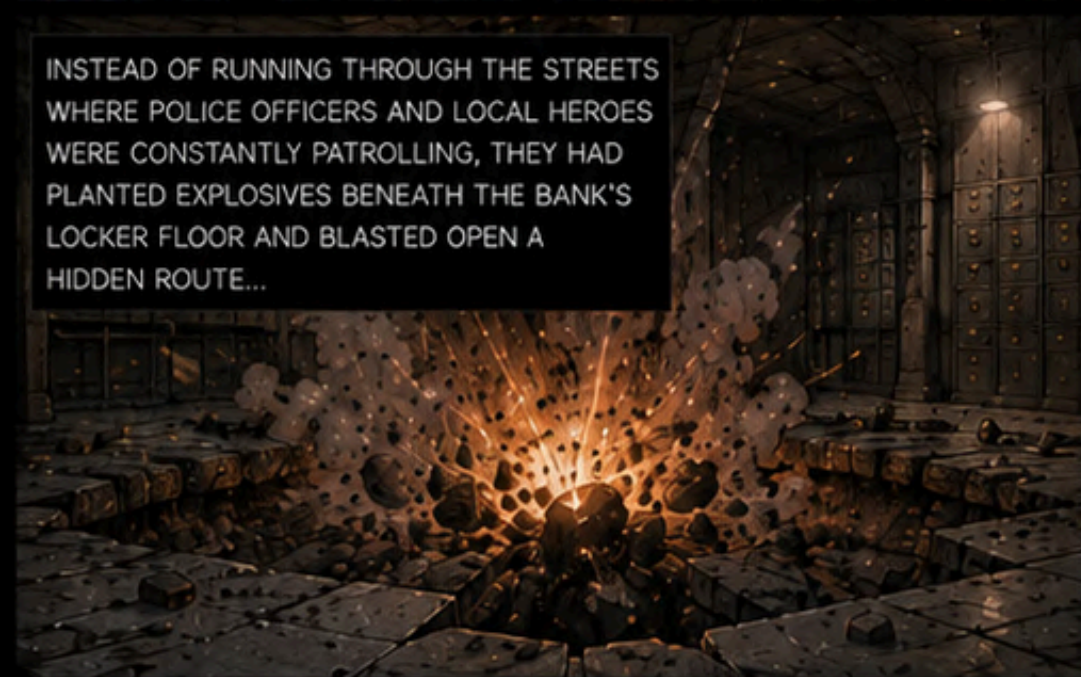
SEVERAL STREETS AWAY FROM THE MEMORIAL...



ALARM BUZZERING ALL OVER THE BANK. THEIR ROBBERY HAD BEEN CAREFULLY PLANNED.



INSTEAD OF RUNNING THROUGH THE STREETS WHERE POLICE OFFICERS AND LOCAL HEROES WERE CONSTANTLY PATROLLING, THEY HAD PLANTED EXPLOSIVES BENEATH THE BANK'S LOCKER FLOOR AND BLASTED OPEN A HIDDEN ROUTE...

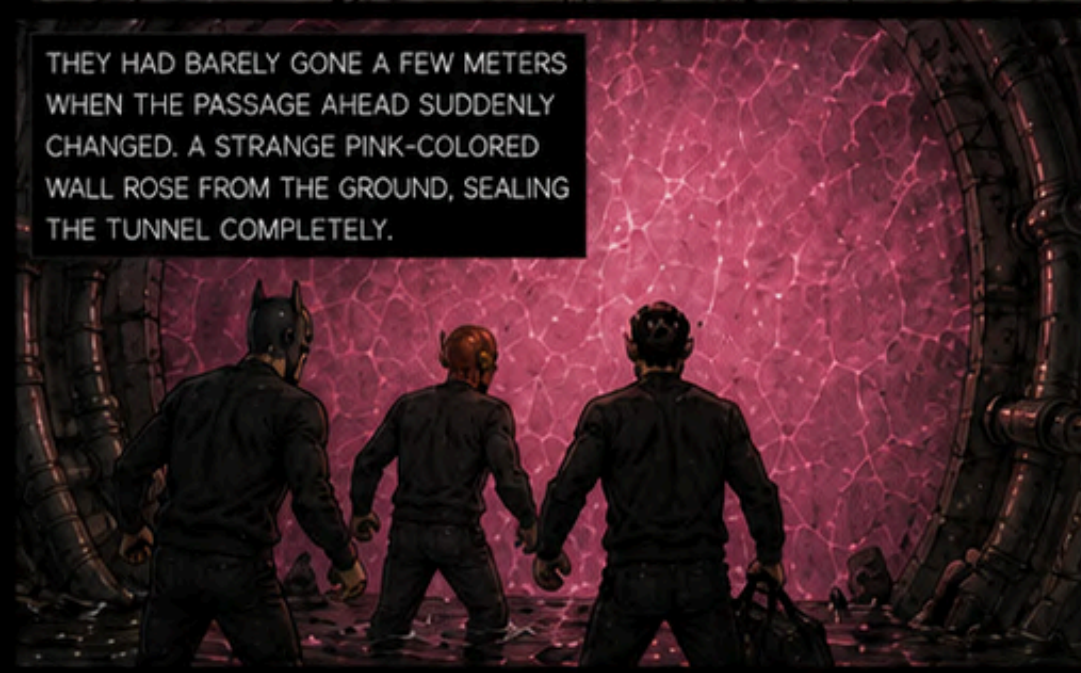


LEADING INTO THE UNDERGROUND SEWAGE SYSTEM.

SURFACE IS TOO RISKY.
TOO MANY HEROES.



THEY HAD BARELY GONE A FEW METERS WHEN THE PASSAGE AHEAD SUDDENLY CHANGED. A STRANGE PINK-COLORED WALL ROSE FROM THE GROUND, SEALING THE TUNNEL COMPLETELY.



THE ROBBERS STOPPED IN CONFUSION.



ONE OF THEM PULLED OUT A WEAPON AND FIRED AT IT.



NOTHING HAPPENED. BULLETS FELL.

ANOTHER SWUNG A METAL PIPE AGAINST THE SURFACE...



...BUT THE WALL DIDN'T EVEN CRACK.

"WHAT THE HELL IS THIS?" HE SHOUTED.



THEY ATTACKED IT TOGETHER, BUT THE WALL REMAINED COMPLETELY INTACT.







BREAKING NEWS
ANOTHER ROBBERY STOPPED
BY A MUTANT TEEN MEMBER ATOM GIRL



THIS IS
"NOTHING," HE SAID
WITHOUT LOOKING
AWAY FROM THE
TELEVISION.

BREAKING NEWS

ANOTHER ROBBERY STOPPED
BY A MUTANT TEEN MEMBER ATOM GIRL

THEY WILL
NOT REMEMBER
YOUR NAME.

YOU ARE
SHORTLISTED FOR THE
GUARDIAN SYNDICATE
RECRUIT TOMORROW.

GET A PLACE IN
THERE. LEAVE THIS
MUTANT TEEN TEAM
BEHIND AND MAKE
US PROUD.



SHE HAD SPENT YEARS
PROTECTING HER
NEIGHBORHOOD, STOPPING
PETTY CRIMINALS, RESCUING
PEOPLE, AND LEARNING TO
MASTER HER ABILITIES
WITHOUT ANYONE TAKING
HER SERIOUSLY.

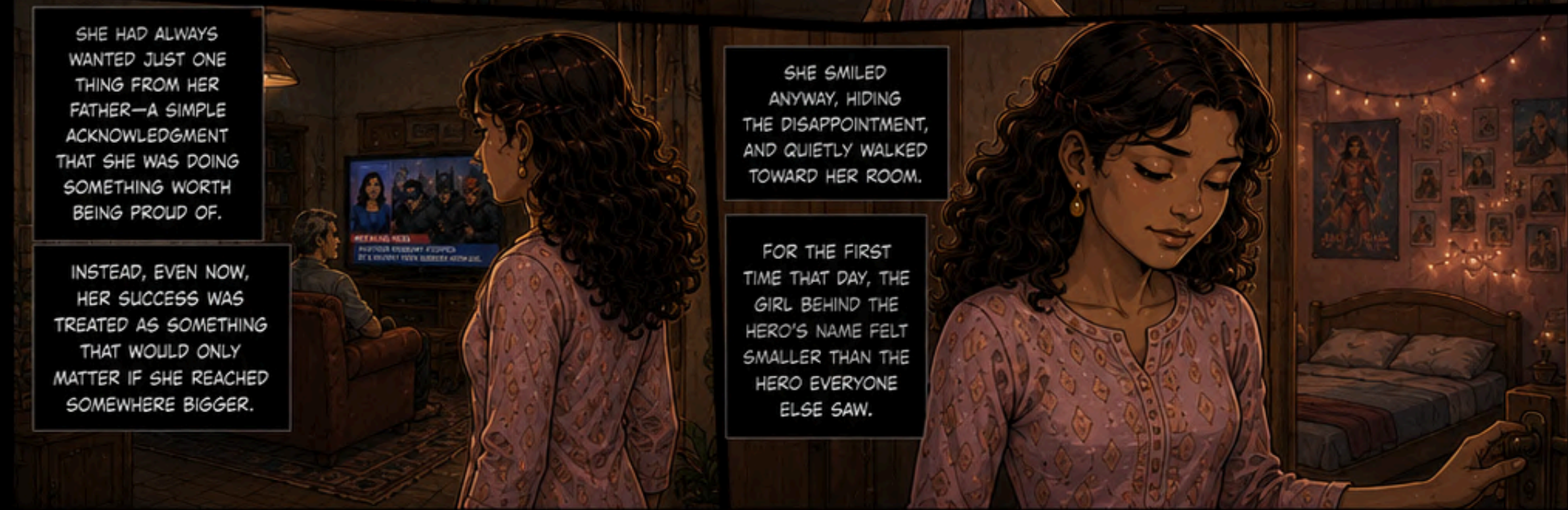


SHE HAD ALWAYS
WANTED JUST ONE
THING FROM HER
FATHER—A SIMPLE
ACKNOWLEDGMENT
THAT SHE WAS DOING
SOMETHING WORTH
BEING PROUD OF.

INSTEAD, EVEN NOW,
HER SUCCESS WAS
TREATED AS SOMETHING
THAT WOULD ONLY
MATTER IF SHE REACHED
SOMEWHERE BIGGER.

SHE SMILED
ANYWAY, HIDING
THE DISAPPOINTMENT,
AND QUIETLY WALKED
TOWARD HER ROOM.

FOR THE FIRST
TIME THAT DAY, THE
GIRL BEHIND THE
HERO'S NAME FELT
SMALLER THAN THE
HERO EVERYONE
ELSE SAW.



THE NEXT DAY MORNING, ATOM GIRL ARRIVED AT THE GUARDIANS SYNDICATE HEADQUARTERS.



AND THAT MORNING THE ENTIRE ENTRANCE WAS CROWDED WITH LOCAL SUPERHEROES WAITING FOR THEIR RECRUITMENT ASSESSMENTS.



QUEEN REMAINED COMPLETELY SERIOUS, CUTTING THROUGH HAZARD'S DISTRACTIONS.



THEN ANSWER ME THIS.
BELLY MAN WAS ONE OF THE SEVEN GUARDIANS. HE WAS POWERFUL, EXPERIENCED, AND RESPECTED BY EVERYONE.
NOW THAT HE IS GONE, HOW DO YOU THINK YOU CAN REPLACE HIM?

ATOM GIRL LOOKED AT QUEEN FOR A MOMENT.

AROUND THE ROOM, THE QUESTION SEEMED TO CARRY THE WEIGHT OF THE ENTIRE PREVIOUS DAY'S MEMORIAL.

SHE COULD HAVE TALKED ABOUT HER STRENGTH, HER ABILITIES OR EVERYTHING SHE HAD ACCOMPLISHED AS A NEIGHBORHOOD HERO.

I'M NOT HERE TO FILL ANYONE'S PLACE.
I'M HERE TO SHOW WHO I AM, AND HOW WELL I CAN HELP PEOPLE.
BELLY MAN WAS BELLY MAN. I COULD NEVER REPLACE HIM, AND I DON'T THINK ANYONE SHOULD TRY TO.
BUT IF YOU GIVE ME A CHANCE, I'LL BECOME THE BEST VERSION OF MYSELF AND USE EVERYTHING I HAVE TO PROTECT PEOPLE.

QUEEN REMAINED SILENT FOR A MOMENT, CLEARLY IMPRESSED BY THE ANSWER.

HAZARD EVEN STOPPED TALKING.

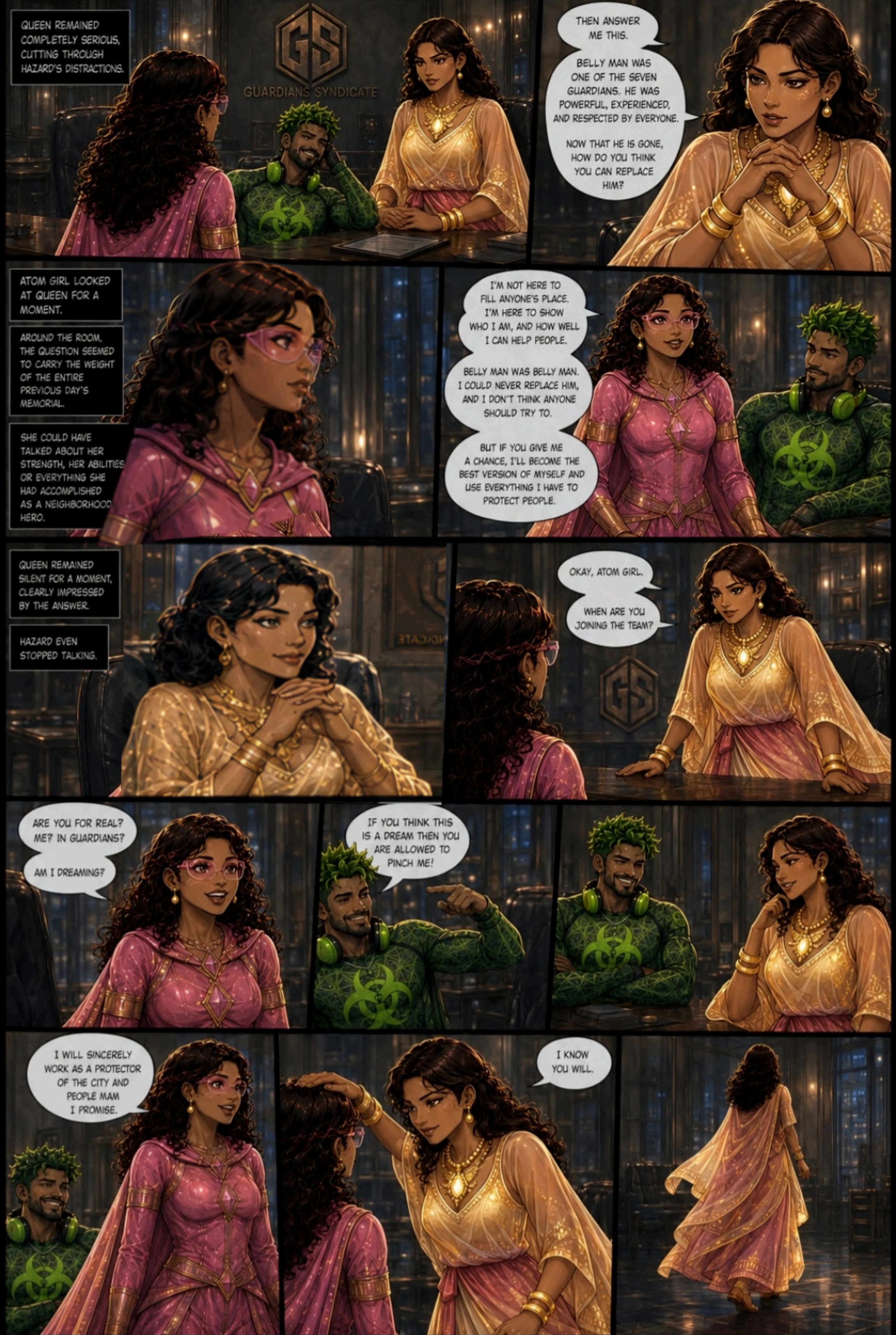
OKAY, ATOM GIRL.
WHEN ARE YOU JOINING THE TEAM?

ARE YOU FOR REAL? ME? IN GUARDIANS?
AM I DREAMING?

IF YOU THINK THIS IS A DREAM THEN YOU ARE ALLOWED TO PINCH ME!

I WILL SINCERELY WORK AS A PROTECTOR OF THE CITY AND PEOPLE MAM I PROMISE.

I KNOW YOU WILL.





I'VE SEEN
THIS PLACE
BEFORE.

THE SAME PLACE
FROM THE DREAM
I HAD LAST NIGHT--
OR AT LEAST,
I BELIEVED IT WAS.



I DIDN'T COME
HERE FOR A MISSION.
I DON'T EVEN KNOW
WHY I'M HERE.



I'VE SEEN
THIS PLACE
BEFORE.

WHY DOES IT
FEEL SO
FAMILIAR?



TWO CHILDREN
RUNNING IN
THE PARK...
ONE CHASING
THE OTHER.



BUT NO FACES.
NO VOICES.
NO CLEAR
EMOTIONS.

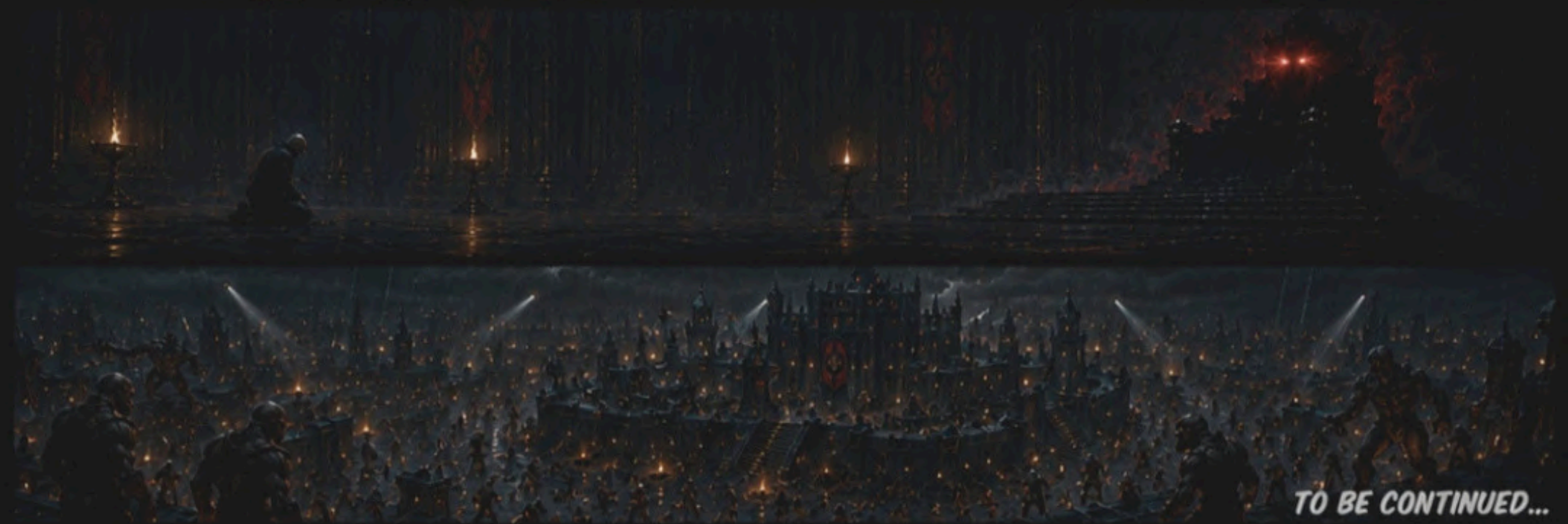
JUST PIECES...
DISCONNECTED.



NO...
NOTHING
CLEAR.

THE MEMORY
SLIPS AWAY
AGAIN.





TO BE CONTINUED...